



A PRABHA

“

Hard work makes the difference. That is how poorer countries like Ethiopia and Kenya win golds at the Olympics.

BHAGWAN NAGARGOJE, Athletic coach

”

weather,” says Rameshwar Chitgire, easily the best bet so far of the project called Sagroli Sunrise. The 20-year-old undergraduate has won several cross-country events for Maharashtra and is hot on the heels of several seasoned runners from the Indian Railways and Services. Others, among the 30 boys and 20 girls under Nagargoje’s wings, have excelled in their age group contests at the national level and now look forward to better exposure and even international rewards.

Backed by the Sanskriti Samvardhan Mandal, an umbrella organisation of schools in Nanded district and two low profile corporate sponsors—Deepak

Kanegaokar, the Sagroli Sunrise Project convener, and Sridhar Rao, a Chennai-based consultant—the starry-eyed athletes and Nagargoje do not have to worry about resources at all. Sagroli Sunrise offers incentives for time-targeted performance in its quest to develop excellence in the children through year-round running. The project authorities feel that this is a sensible approach as there is no better incentive than cash for these impoverished children. Clearly, this is a more meticulously planned strategy than the Special Area Games Programme that the Sports Authority of India drew up in the euphoria of the country’s commendable performance at the 1982 Asian Games in Delhi. Region-specific sports, like contact sports in the North-eastern states and rowing and kayaking in coastal Kerala, were encouraged. But, like most government-sponsored sports initiatives, it lost steam in a few years.

“All-out efforts will bear fruit in a couple of years,” says the optimistic Sagroli Vidyalaya Principal Arvind Deshmukh. At the moment though, he and Nagargoje plan to take 10 of their best runners to Beijing, confident that they are not awestruck by the sight and sounds when they possibly run for India at the London Olympics in 2012.